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Winard Harper

Winard Harper was born in Baltimore in 1962 and was inspired to pursue jazz drumming when he heard a recording of Clifford Brown and Max Roach. He has performed with Dexter Gordon and Betty Carter, and co-led the Harper Brothers Quintet with his brother Phillip. He is one of the most in-demand drummers in jazz today

Winard was interviewed in Utica, New York on October 10, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at the Hotel Utica and I'm speaking with drummer and band leader Winard Harper. Welcome to Utica.

WH: Hey, thank you. Good to be here.

MR: Is it your first time in Utica?

WH: You know it might be. It might be.

MR: Well at home I have the three volume *Grove Encyclopedia of Jazz*, and I looked you up and you are in there and you have a photo too.

WH: Get out.

MR: You do. And not everybody gets a photo. So congratulations on your career so far.

WH: Oh, thank you.

MR: If you went to a party and people questioned you about making a career in jazz, and they say well what's that like, trying to be a jazz musician — do you have an answer for them?

WH: Wow now that's a big and deep question. Because I think when I was coming along, as a young man coming out of school and stuff, it was different than what it is today. So that's almost like two totally different worlds. I think at that age, for a lot of us coming out of school I want to say in the 80s, you know it was different. There seemed to be more opportunities and a lot of hope. Now it's a little tougher.

MR: Well what were the opportunities that were there before that aren't here now?

WH: Well I think one, first off, there were more venues. There were more places to play. When we came along I could at least say maybe in almost every major city there was at least one club or place that you could hope to play and work. It's not quite that way today. And then on top of that what a lot of us that came along let's say late 70s, 80s, there were some bands you could play in. You could go apprentice with somebody. You know Art Blakey was still around; Betty Carter; Horace Silver, that band; Sonny Rollins. I mean that's just off the top of my head, a few of the bands. And now there's not enough work for a lot of guys to even keep a regular working band.

MR: Yeah, to keep the same group of people together. And you did that.

WH: Yeah. We're still trying to do that. That's why I'm saying we're getting beat up bad. But when we came along, say me and the first band I played in with Betty Carter, me and Benny Green, that was a band we could sit in and work, rehearse, go out of the road, and I did it for four years. Most of us pretty much had like a four year run with her. And the same thing with a lot of guys that worked with Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers — a place you could go sit and hone your craft, learn, for about three or four years.

MR: That was like your college.

WH: Pretty much.

MR: So why is it — I guess it's an obvious thing here, why can't that happen now? Javon Jackson and you and other people in that generation, it's just harder to keep a group performing.

WH: Part of it is there's not enough places to play, there again. Nowadays when I look at trying to book gigs and book tours — and it's not just me, this is from talking with other guys — there was a time where you could go out and say okay, well I'm going to play this place for a week, I know I'm here Tuesday through Sunday. If I get lucky maybe I can find something on the Monday. You know what I mean? And in most of the cities you'd go and play that jazz venue for a week. Now, a lot of times if these cities have jazz venues — during the week nowadays is very — you don't even see that that often. Sometimes not even New York. New York is kind of like that. The Vanguard you still may see a week. Very few places do you see that Tuesday through Sunday anymore. So it's gotten a lot harder. So as a band leader when you're trying to take a band out, nowadays I mean most places will want to hire you for the weekend. Then you've got to try to figure out what am I doing Monday through Thursday? Am I sitting around paying a hotel bill or am I going to pay to send everybody back and come back again. So it's a lot tougher since you've got to try to find, okay, how can I fill up the week and not have so many off days. Because off days obviously you're paying hotels or whatever. So it's just a lot tougher. There's less places to play and a lot of that's because more steps need to be made to replenish the jazz audience.

MR: It's ironic because jazz, like in academia now, is flourishing. Every college and, you know, at least has some jazz presence. And also you can major in jazz and so forth. It doesn't translate to the club scene.

WH: No because some great steps and pioneers put work in on jazz education. You know, the guy who worked for 15 years or so, Dr. Billy Taylor, Joe Newman, guys like Nathan Davis, some of those pioneers fought for and helped put jazz education in place where now most of your major colleges have jazz programs, which at one time, even when I came out of high school that was rare. A lot of schools didn't have jazz programs. But

now all these schools have jazz programs. So we've done a lot to bring along musicians, but we haven't done enough to bring along people for them to play for. So that's where we lack. We have to come up now with some thought and some ways of building and replenishing the jazz audience. Getting some people to say look, this is something worthwhile. This is something that we need to have our young people check out. We need to have them grow with.

MR: And how do you do that? Do you have any ideas?

WH: It's like anything — it's going to be more than one thing that gets it taken care of. I think one thing is in the educational system — we have to start early though. We can't wait to introducing people to it by the time they're 18 and 19. We need to start early. We need to put some programs in, you know, the elementary schools, the high schools. Where we can play for the kids and show them, give them some of the history, show them that not only is it a great, powerful music, but it's also fun, you know, it's uplifting. Just some other things have to be done with it. Because there was a time when most of the TV themes were jazz-based. Now all that — it's very rare. So for most kids growing up they're lucky if they hear anything.

MR: It's funny you mention that, because a lot of the TV themes now, I'll challenge somebody, whistle the theme from *Law & Order*. They're sounds almost, some of them. It's cool, but I know what you're talking about. It's not like "Peter Gunn."

WH: Oh yeah it's not like — I remember hearing *I Dream of Jeannie*, or *Mission Impossible*, or even *Star Trek*. You know that theme's kind of based on "Out of Nowhere."

MR: I never thought of that.

WH: You think about *The Flintstones*, which doesn't come on anymore. So you had a lot of shows that, you know they were jazz based, you know. And the music had some content. Think about *Hawaii 5-0*.

MR: If you had a little audience and you were trying to get them turned on to jazz, and you had an hour or something and you had a CD player, what kind of recordings would you pick from jazz history?

WH: I would try to squeeze in as much real live recordings. Some Louis Armstrong, some Duke Ellington, Billie Holiday of course and then probably get to some Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers. Cannonball. I mean there would be so much I would try to pack in. And I would try to pick a lot of those things that I think brought me along, that turned me on to the music. Clifford Brown and Max Roach. But singers. Singers I think is always a good way of coming in.

[Phone ringing. Excuse me for a moment]

MR: Sure. Well you said a magic word just now, Cannonball. Man he was my, and still is, he's like it. He had everything. He was a wonderful saxophone player, or anybody could —

WH: It was a great band. Because the first band I had, my brother and myself, the Harper Brothers. Of course me being the drummer, everybody thought more that we patterned this after Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers. But the band that I was turned on by was Cannonball's band.

MR: With Roy McCurdy or with Louis Hayes?

WH: Louis Hayes, Sam Jones. But I mean Roy McCurdy is a good friend. I love that band too. But all the bands were good, but it was just the way that Cannonball played, the way he approached the music. Everything, I mean the dance was in the music. That's the key. When you heard Cannonball I mean it would get you dancing. The dance was in the music and everything they played sounded fun. It reached you. It hit you in the soul. And it was funny because one of the bands I had later on I remember I had George Cables play with me for quite some time. You know we would talk and tell stories, we'd be on the road driving. And he was telling us a story one time about him getting called to make a rehearsal with Cannonball. And at the time I think he thought well wow, making this rehearsal, I'll be making the gig. But it was just a rehearsal. But he was telling us that when he played the rehearsal, and I guess they all got there before Cannonball did, and they are playing. And when Cannon came and Cannon started playing he was like, oh shucks. You know he said his sound was so big and he swung so hard, George would say one thing he remembered he says, "man, he don't even need a band." Because you know that's the way Cannon plays, the stuff just swung so hard.

MR: He did. He played like he was, I mean he just played with his personality almost. He just was so erudite and, that was great. Great stuff. What did you learn from people like Betty Carter and Dexter Gordon, that generation. Anything that you can pass on?

WH: A lot of everything. A lot of music, but partly more life than anything. Because one thing about Betty that I always admired was her strength, and she was tenacious. She was going to find a way to get it done. And we miss that. And I think the music misses that, those kind of people like that. Betty, you know, she would think — if a door was closed she used to go open up something somewhere else. Because I remember many times just asking her questions all the time. And she had ways of, okay well if this club is not going to hire me well I don't like that club and I'm going to do this, we'll go in here, we'll play this city but we'll play here. You know sometimes too she would rent out a theater or space and she put herself in concert. So I really admired that and it helped me a lot when I started the Harper Brothers. So business-wise I learned a lot of from Betty and her strength, and just how to keep a band and how to try to get what you want from everybody. Keep everybody on the same page and playing the music.

MR: Was she tough with her accompanists?

WH: Sure. But it was — I always looked at it like a boot camp. You know what I mean? You know if you come in there and you get through this then you're ready for any- and everything. And then when I looked at the history of it, come to find out a lot of the guys that played with her, when they came out into the scene, when they got from beyond her, they were — they could handle just about anything you threw at them. And I think a lot of the other guys around knew that. Well this guy played with Betty so I know he's going to be sound, he's going to know a lot of tunes. So those things came with the territory. So I kind of felt like if you can get through that, you know, you can make it and you can do it well and you've graduated. So she was tough but in a good way as long as you looked at it the right way. You know, you had to see the light at the end of the tunnel.

MR: When you do — I'm not sure how to say this question — when you do your taxes at the end of the year and you look where your income comes from, how much of it is from live gigs and how much is it from other things like teaching or workshops.

WH: For me, and I don't know if this is a good thing or a bad thing, it's still pretty much live. I'm still at — because of the way I came up with the people I came up with, I'm still a diehard in terms of that. I'm going to try to make a gig some kind of way, even if I have to create one. Because I feel like getting the music and getting it live is the best thing. And I'm on this mission too of trying to replenish the jazz audience. So I'm trying to take the music into places that people may not normally get it, trying to take it to some of the children and schools. And the past couple of years in Jersey City I've had a program where I'll go into a lot of different public schools and play the music for the kids. I have a little neighborhood place that I use in Jersey City where I have a jam session on Fridays and once a month, at the beginning of the month, I have a little jazz concert. So I'm still always trying to make it because I feel like it's the best way to get the music. And especially for people that are experiencing music for the first time. Because the recordings are great too but we live in such a visual age now with everything, with being able to see videos and whatnot. I think for them to be able to see and get the whole experience is a good thing.

MR: Yeah it's a very YouTube world.

WH: Right.

MR: And being able to talk intelligently with an audience is important too. The whole idea of the jazz musician just not communicating with their voice too I think doesn't help the music.

WH: Sure. It may help you get close, the intimacy of it, and a lot of times I think for people that don't know, when they first hear that term well this is jazz music, everybody thinks oh, it's going to be boring, it's going to be so intellectual, you know, I don't understand

it, what are they playing, where are they going? So sometimes to experience it live and to see people having fun, to see people interacting I think counteracts all that.

MR: Yeah. That phrase like, "well after they're done playing the melody I just don't get it anymore, like what are they doing?"

WH: Yeah that happens.

MR: And you got into the balafon over the years. What prompted that?

WH: Different work experiences. I spent a little time with Jackie McLean, kind of, so I spent some time with Jackie McLean in the very early 80's when I first came out of D.C., Jackie brought my brother and I to the University of Hartford and we went to school there for a minute. So Jackie, I took a history class with him where we studied some of the African music, you know, the roots of jazz. So it got me into thinking about a lot of African traditions. Then when I got to New York and I started to work with Betty and then in the meantime of working with Betty I also started doing some gigs with Abdullah Ibrahim. So there, now I'm getting some South African flavor and playing with some of the other great African musicians that he knew. At the same time or a little before that I had met and become very, very good friends with Billy Higgins. We had become like really close where we would share music. If he came to New York he'd come to my house — he'd come in and we'd play drums and play stuff. I'd go to L.A., he'd come get me, go over his house, we'd play, and he would start showing me some of the different instruments that he played. Because Billy could pick up a little bit of everything and play. You know, guitar and stuff. So the first thing he showed me was this little box, we called it a slit drum. It's like a wooden box. You've seen them, they've got slabs cut up on the top where they get different notes. So he showed me one of those and I started playing it. Oh yeah. So when you check out some of my first recordings that's what I'm using, it's a slit drum. And then it just got me to being curious and every time I'd get to these different cities I'd go to the music stores or I'd be playing on a festival or something — it'd be an African festival so I'd go down and check out some of the instruments. And one day I found a little balafon, a small balafon. And I started playing it. So I said you know what? This would be even easier to carry than a slit drum and I liked the sound. So I started messing around with the balafon. And that's how that came in.

MR: And does it inspire composition?

WH: Sure. Just because the sound, being the way that they're made and from different tribes and different parts of Africa, all of them are different. So if you'd come by my house I've got like almost 10 or 15. I kind of collect them. Because I'll play them for a while for a different sound and melodies will come out of different ones for me. So I have several of them. Because the tone system and the scales that they use, they're never the same.

MR: Yeah, they just had a fellow at Hamilton last week with an mbira and he basically was saying the same thing, that the scale intonation can actually vary from one village to the next.

WH: Yeah. Which is really, really nice and slick in itself. Because everything has an identity. And I guess for a lot of them, they hear them and they can tell, okay I know that sound, I know where that's coming from. But it's the same way with the music, which is interesting too. Because even with the drummers, that's why with a lot of my students I tell them they have to go — because I got it from Jackie — they have to go study the history of this music. If you really want to play this music and play it well and with the best intentions, you have to do a study of jazz history. And you can't do that without starting in Africa. Because for them, when they play those drums, it's a language. They're talking. Those guys will sit down and they're playing stuff and people that know them will hear them and they'll know what they're saying. You know what I mean? So it's very, very interesting. Because as you know from checking out some of my CD's, I have used a lot of different African drummers over the years. And one of the last guys I used, Alioune Faye, his whole family plays. And there have been times when we would get to different cities where some of his family is living and they'll come and sit in. You know we'll do workshops and I'll let them play. And they'll break it down, they'll tell us, well if he plays this I know he's calling me. That's my name. So it's really slick and interesting.

MR: My daughter actually plays in an African drum ensemble in Rochester. And I go to see them. It's led by a fellow from West Africa. And it would annoy me — the music was incredible but I would get annoyed when I couldn't put — where's 1? You know, I'd lose it. And I don't think I should be annoyed but I kept trying to codify it into something I could feel like I understood.

WH: Yeah, for them it's there. It's just like, you know, they have whatever that clave is, that gets held down, because one of those instruments usually is holding everything down, where you can say okay — but then all of them polyrhythms go on top. And that's where you start to hear all these other voices. But there's something nailing it, holding it down. But it's so interesting. And that's what jazz, how jazz evolved, out of that. Jazz is still a language. It's speaking. It should be saying something. And sometimes my problem with some of the stuff that comes out today, sometimes I don't think people think about that and they're not really trying to say anything. When you go back and you listen to Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong, Charlie Parker, John Coltrane, you know, and guys we talked about, Harry "Sweets" Edison and Frank Wess. They were saying something. There was some intent. It wasn't just I'm just going to get up here and have a good time.

You know it was that, it was a part of that, but there was still some other very meaningful —

MR: It's interesting how technology has affected things like, in the days when they were making records they were on 78s, they had three minutes to do their thing. And it affected the way they played I think. Because then the LPs, they said oh I've got 30 minutes on a side.

WH: Yeah. I can see that.

MR: I want to make sure we're — yeah, we're picking up a nice vacuum cleaner here. Okay. I have a couple of audio things I'd like you to comment on if you don't mind. This is not really what *DownBeat* would have called a blindfold test, but —
[audio interlude]
Nice, huh?

WH: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. I wrote one on there.

MR: What is it about that, for you, that is just so — it gets you in the heart?

WH: That song, it swings. And like I said, for me I guess when I think about a lot of those guys in that era, you know, the intent that they played with, for me, you can feel all that. You can't get away from it. Higgins, Art Blakey. I'd say we were tight. Because I loved his sound. And the way he played was his personality.

MR: You know some people would go oh wait a minute, what do you mean you love his sound? Like how can you tell one drummer from another?

WH: Well especially in that period with a lot of the great players, it's just like when you would talk to some people that might be into let's say metaphysics and spiritual things, when they talk about everybody has an aura you know. A guy's sound is like his aura. Just like when you were talking about Cannonball. It was his personality. And it comes through the horns. And still with a lot of players you can see that their personalities would transcend and come through the instrument. Some of the inner things that you don't see unless you know them well, all of that will tend to come out. Like you might have some guys that you think are just quiet, they don't say a whole lot. But then when they play you say wow, that's kind of surprising. But if you got to know them you'd know that that's coming out of what is inside. So that's a lot of what their sound and their personality is.

MR: Does it have also, the way they tune their drums or, sort of the gear thing?

WH: There's some aspects of that. There's some of it. But it's not totally. Because I mean I've spent so much time going to see Higgins and let him use my drums, you know what I mean? Or Art Blakey. Or hearing those stories about Art Blakey getting to the gig, they were on tour somewhere in Europe and there was no drums you know what I mean. But there were some cases over in the corner so he pulled out the cases and played the cases. You know what I mean? You know, and those guys, through their personalities still make

the music work. I remember Higgins telling me stories about that period when he was, you know, life was really a struggle for him. He had pawned his drums and he'd come to the gig and no drums. And he'd go in the back of the Vanguard and come out with a phone book and a coat hanger or something, and still make a gig. You'd hear about guys playing a pie pan, and they could still — you know their sound is there.

MR: You know Carl Allen told this anecdote about Billy Higgins. He was playing in a club and he says that he was just sort of not really doing it. And all of a sudden this hand came over and took over on the ride cymbal and it was Billy Higgins. And he said the whole room just like —

WH: Lit up.

MR: That's amazing that a person could have that kind of force without bashing.

WH: Right. Because I mean, like I said, it's that inside, that intent, where you know how to give what you need, and so much spiritual energy is coming out through you, that you are able to bring up and call forth. But I mean if anybody knew Cannonball you'd hear some of the same stories about Cannonball. People tell me man, Cannon's personality, even when he wasn't playing, if he walked in the room it was just something about him, you just knew Cannon was there. Well that's the same way with his sound. So a lot of guys are like that. You know, Art Blakey, Elvin [Jones] and guys, I mean Billy Taylor. He's another one. When you've heard him play, his sound fit his personality. Genuine, no frills, just down to earth, the right thing.

MR: Okay, let me try another one here.

[audio interlude]

That's wonderful.

WH: Yeah, yeah.

MR: An interesting combination of people: Ellington and Mingus and Max Roach. I wouldn't have guessed that that would gel.

WH: Yeah, I would, I would. What was that, "Money Jungle?"

MR: Yeah.

WH: Yeah it would because I think — I never met Duke Ellington or Mingus. I knew Max, I knew Max well. Max was really my start into the music. And he was a big help in my career. But just knowing, like I said, there again, understanding him, what he played for, his intentions and everything, his love for the music, his love for history. I knew how, and when you hear all of those guys talking about Duke Ellington, there's a deep respect. You know what I mean? So with guys like that I don't care who everybody else is you're going to come and you're going to find a way. Look, we're playing with Duke Ellington. I mean it's like you figure if Louis Armstrong came along and, whoever he wanted to hire, the guy's going to find a way to empty my glass and we're going to get filled up and

we're going to make this work you know. So those guys, their intent and their love for the music, you figure that's going to carry. Mingus or another great bassist and a great composer, and you have an opportunity to work with Duke Ellington, of course.

MR: Wasn't there a story about Ellington had to let Charles Mingus go or something? He got into a — oh there's some anecdote about he got into a hassle with Juan Tizol.

WH: That one I never heard.

MR: Yeah it's out there. It sounded like Max was playing with really thin sticks to me, that sound. Is that an assumption that I can make or don't you really know?

WH: I never really thought about it. It could be. But I know too, I can tell the drums are tuned kind of high. The way Max plays, I mean, he's another one, the sound always came through. But he's another one, he was a good composer, and when he played the drums he was always composing.

MR: His music took a political stance often, and there was something on your website I saw where you said, if everyone listened to jazz once a day that it could make a difference in the world. And I wonder if you still feel that way.

WH: Sure. Because I think, I guess Max's stance could be viewed as political. I view it more as life. And that's what I meant. I think that music to them was much more important than it is for a lot of people today. And I mean some of the musicians playing it. Because their playing it wasn't just to be playing to make music or just to make money or just 'cause I can do it. They were still trying to say something through the music. And when you go back and you listen and read some interviews you'll hear them talk about that, through the music. They were saying something. Because they came through a time which is not much different from everything that's going on in the news today. It's not much different than what we're dealing with today. And they were dealing with it then and they were trying to say through the music, look we are all human. This is life. And to me nothing says that as much as jazz does.

MR: Why?

WH: Because I think it's always been — it's pioneered a lot of things. It's gone into a lot of places, a lot of countries, and brought people together. It's made people respect, I think too, in terms of dealing with some of the racial issues I think the jazz musicians and the music, without a lot of people talking about this, went to the forefront of a lot of that, pioneering, and that has to be talked about. Even a lot of other things we've seen the jazz musicians were some of the first people to go into these places or do some of these things, and because of them playing the music people had to say wait a minute, this is not easy stuff that these guys were doing. So that already debunked the myth that these people are unintelligent. So for the guys to get the sound and play the things they were playing and for them being investigated, and then for them to be gracious and giving

enough to say, come on, I can show you. And they were some of the first ones. You know you would go into some of those after-hours places and you'll see all kinds of people, white, black people, just enjoying the music. And you'd start seeing guys play together. And on the bandstand, look, I'm going to hire this person because I like what they can do, they should be heard. You know what I mean? So the music, to me, through my studying would be inside the forefront of a lot of it. And I think it still should be.

MR: Is there any — a number of years ago a *Jazz Times* came out and the cover of it said "Race Matters." And it was a coverage of a symposium they had had. And people like Nat Hentoff and a group of people were talking about, I guess, does race matter in jazz now? Now that was a few years ago, but I wonder, is there any racial disharmony or is it even an issue anymore?

WH: It's always an issue because it's an issue socially. So it's always something that has to be worked on. It's always something that should be thought about and not just in terms of black and white. You know there's other issues that are coming across now because there's always so much — the shakedown of the devil, he's 24/7. He will never give up. So he's always stirring up something. And we see it from time to time with the plight of Jewish people having to go through or the Muslims or somebody else moves in the neighborhood that looks different, is different, speaks different, you know, mental health. It's all kind of issues that need to be addressed. And I think somewhat the music helps with that. Music puts us all — because early on for me, when I would come out and do some of these concerts and work with some of the people I work with, and you look out in the audience and for me that was some of the first times I could look out [phone ringing].

MR: You were talking about the audience you were playing for.

WH: Yeah. Some of the first jazz concerts I did I could look out in the audience and see all kinds of different people from all different kinds of walks of life sitting there enjoying the music or getting up dancing. You know what I mean? Really everybody not thinking about, no arguments where somebody else is from or I'm standing next to this guy and he's this — not a problem. So, you know, in my mind, you know and maybe some of it was optimism and some of it was being young, but in my mind it's like why can't we take this and magnify it and take it everywhere.

MR: I wish I knew the answer to that one.

WH: Well the answer is it's a job for all of us, in all walks of life, whatever you do. Everybody can take it and take the fundamentals and the essence of jazz and apply it. Because sometimes you even hear stories about some of these bands — like I've heard somebody tell me some stories about Duke Ellington's band saying you know nobody in that band got along. I mean I never heard, I might have to do some checking into it further, see a lot

of those guys didn't like each other which is kind of amazing. Because if that was the case, then that too says that look, they understood that even if that was the case, you had some problem with somebody, when they got on the bandstand, that bandstand was sacred. We're going to take care of business. We're going to spread the love, and this is the thread that's going to tie us all together. So that's a great thing. Music is powerful. I remember one time too, maybe Frank Wess told me this story and then I think Buddy Catlett confirmed it. You know Buddy Catlett was one of the bass players that played with Basie and I knew Buddy Catlett well from my travels in Seattle. But I think Frank told me that one time they were out on the road and Buddy Catlett and whatchacalit, who was the drummer at the time?

MR: Gus Johnson maybe?

WH: No, no, no.

MR: Oh Sonny Payne?

WH: Sonny. They shared a room together. And they were good buddies but I guess they both got to drinking. And they got into an argument over something. And he said they just tore up the room. They beat each other up. And the two of them got up the next morning and they had to go make the gig. So I mean the music overrides.

MR: Yeah. Musicians are people too you know, but they had their foibles. It's funny, the difference that Sonny Payne made in that band, like when you did that thing with your arms. I remember Joe Williams talking about that, that he really lit a fire under that group. Okay I was going to try one more thing for you here.
[audio interlude]

WH: That's an old one.

MR: Yeah. Do you remember the date?

WH: No, I'm not even sure I have that one in my collection.

MR: Houston Person.

WH: Yes Houston Person with Joey DeFrancesca.

MR: Yeah. I think it might have been called "Why Not" or it might have been the Young Lions.

WH: The Young Lion and his Cub [The Lion and His Pride]. Yeah I remember. Who was playing guitar?

MR: I can't remember. But your brother's on it.

WH: Yeah, yeah. Like I was saying, the sound, you know what I mean?

MR: Do you ever, when you're doing those four bar breaks, eight bar breaks or whatever, do you plan ahead for the next break? There was a guy, I read a quote, someone in the *Washington Post* reviewing, you were playing with someone and it said "wonderfully orchestrated solos."

WH: No I'm kind of like — because Max was such a big influence on me too. That was my entrance into jazz. So, and him and all those guys, but I mean him and Higgins both had a big influence on me as well as Elvin and a bunch of other guys, Frankie Dunlop, Billy Hart. So when it comes to solos I'm still trying to compose, you know, like Max. I'm trying to say something. So in my solos, if I've got a solo I may have some ideas and then I'll go forthwith, and then from that something else comes. But on the trading, trading is, for me it's always based on what the horn player plays or the piano player plays, whoever is taking the fours before me. Because if they've said something I'm either trying to continue the statement or answer the statement. So sometimes rhythmically I may hear something in what they played and I may borrow from or take that and start it and go from there. Sometimes it can be a conversation. And then everybody looks and says wow, he hears me. You know what I mean? And then all the doors start opening up with everybody, everybody's giving and taking. It's a wonderful thing playing music. If you think about it, all those things are fundamentals for life. Because you know what it does to somebody when they realize and they find out somebody hears me. I've talked and he's listening. For families, for everything else. Some of it doesn't happen as much as it needs to, even in society. You know that's a lot of what's going on. People are talking and they feel like nobody's listening. Okay like who hears me? And that's what happens on the bandstand a lot of times. I always tell a lot of my students, once you start playing with people, people you've never played with before, you're going to find that once they know that you're listening and you hear them it's going to open up a door. I mean it always happens. You know you might be playing with somebody and they're just thinking about playing the music. And all of a sudden they play something and you catch it and all of a sudden they look up, oh, we're conversating. You know?

MR: I like that word. Conversating. And I have found that the more in tune the rhythm section is the easier it is to play, or the less hard. You're not feeling like you're trying to drag people with you or something. It becomes a group effort. So tonight, when you play with — three of the four other guys in the band are in their 70s and 80s. Do you go into that situation thinking I need to change my playing? Or, as opposed to when you might be working with your own quintet?

WH: I try to mostly go into situations, like I told you, I try to, before I walk out that door I try to make sure look empty my glass so I can come with an empty cup and bring something back. If you're going to a buffet and you've got two sandwiches in your bag, you know what I mean? So I try to make sure I'm open so I can receive. I can see. It's like a doctor coming in and before he's even seen you he's already got a diagnosis. You don't want to be that doctor. You want to be a doctor, you know, somebody just told him, it's this. You want to go look and see for yourself. Because it may not be. It may just be some

symptoms. You know. So you want to go get a good idea for yourself. If you already go with things in mind you've already narrowed your scope. So I try to just, like I say, be open, empty myself, so I can go and see what it is or what I'm working with and where it's going to go. Because then maybe we can take things to some different places.

MR: And you've worked with most of these guys before.

WH: Yeah. In different situations. Dick Hyman and I, we've worked together over the years. Jay Leonhart and I have been on some gigs together. The last time I worked with him we might have done Dizzy's with George Wein.

MR: With George Wein?

WH: Yeah.

MR: Oh no kidding.

WH: Yeah it was a band that George Wein had. I think it might have been one of the last times we worked with him.

MR: You know I think the last time I went to a club in New York, I think it was the Iridium. And Ron Carter had a group. It was very good but it was not his group, it was who can I get. But it cost me, this was probably ten years ago, it cost me I think almost $70, by the time I paid the cover and had a couple of drinks. And I'm wondering about two things. Like how does that kind of thing sustain itself, if we're worried about our audience; and also what are those musicians getting paid?

WH: Well it depends and that's what I'm saying, that's one of the difficult things now for jazz. And it's not just jazz, it's life period. Everything is so expensive. And who's to be blamed? I'm not sure. I mean we all know somebody's walking away with a bigger cut of the pie, you know, than it needs to be, where it makes it unfair. But it's caused everything to go up to the point where the little people are getting squeezed out and screaming or complaining. Even these talks about minimum wage. I mean on the one hand the people are talking about it's not enough, I can understand that. Because of the cost of living. I always tell my kids, I mean when I first came to New York, and I've been living over in Jersey for a long time, to get on the Path train, which was just to go from New Jersey to New York, was under a dollar. You know what I mean? It was under a dollar. I think it was maybe like 50 cents or something, just to go — because like the whole ride to go from Jersey to New York is like 20 minutes. So it was under a dollar. Now? It just went up I think a couple of days ago, so now it's $2.75 for one trip. You know what I mean? But over the years it's gone up. I think when I first got to New York, to drive and go through the Holland Tunnel was like $2. Whatever. It was under $5. I mean to go through the Holland Tunnel now, any time I've got to go to work that means every night, to go through that tunnel I have to spend — it costs right now, it's $13. You know what I mean?

MR: A toll?

WH: A toll.

MR: Wow.

WH: And now they're saying that every year all of these are going up a certain amount of money. So I was just telling my kids the other day, so that means look, in another ten years to go from New Jersey to New York by the train is going to be almost a $5 ride. So if you just want to go hang out you're looking at at least $10 just to take the train. Now driving-wise in ten years it may be almost $20 just for the toll. Everything is just —

MR: You know but this occurs to me, and it seems like one of the things that keeps getting cheaper and cheaper to the point of being ridiculous is buying music.

WH: Well that's 'cause musicians aren't making any money. I was just talking to Jimmy Heath the other day and you know we were laughing and talking about the cost of things. And I said yeah everything is going up but what — jazz musicians have been making the same amount of money since I came along. I mean I'm talking to Jimmy Heath who is like 88 or something. And I said I've been here at least 30 years myself. The pay hasn't changed. I mean the garbage man pay has gone up. You know what I mean? But most of the jazz musicians are still making the same amount of money. So that's what I mean, I have to tell a lot of the young guys now, you really have to think about this. Because some of the gigs I used to take, let's say if I was going into New York and I had somebody call me up for a gig. Okay so if it was a hundred dollar gig, you know sometimes I have to think about it. Because you've got already, just off the bat, you put gas in the car, you've spent $13 for the tunnel, if you've got to put your car in the garage, you know you've already spent half your money before you do the gig.

MR: Wow.

WH: So in answer to what you were saying, sometimes that's why those cover charges now are so high. Because it's hard for a jazz club even to sustain itself a lot of times because those rents now, rents for everybody, leases, it's terrible. What they're asking for is just like — I never thought it was going to get to be this expensive.

MR: How old are your kids?

WH: Oh them are all ages. I've got grandkids now. I've got six grandkids. But I've got kids from — the oldest I think is 30, so from 30 down.

MR: If your grandson came to you when he's like let's say 12, 13 years old and says, "I want to be a musician." What do you say to him?

WH: You know that's the thing. Over the years that has changed. And I don't think it's just because I've gotten older but I think the times have changed. Because when I was coming up, I mean people still said the same thing to me, but I think it was for a different reason, because I don't think they saw what this was going to be like now. But even like some

other family members, if you said you were going to be a musician or you said you wanted to be an athlete or something, everybody always told you well look, "have your back-up plan." It was always that when you go to school major in this. And my thoughts then were look there's not going to be a back-up plan. This is what I'm going to do and I'm going to make it work and I'm going to succeed. I'm not thinking about Plan B. Nowadays I don't know if I could really say that, you know, I mean tell my kids that. Because I would say it's just so different. The opportunities that were there for me, I don't really see those opportunities right now for aspiring musicians. Like I say this, I mean I can't tell somebody well if you go to school and you do this and that I'm going to introduce you to so-and-so and you'll be able to go out and do four years with Betty Carter or you can get with Art Blakey, you know, and they'll take you on tour. Right now that's not in place.

MR: And at the same time the universities are graduating a lot more players that are trying to get —

WH: We're all trying to work. There's a lot more players, there's probably more players than there is audience And that's until we work on that aspect of it, until we find ways to start replenishing the audience. But this is like anything else, supply and demand. If we can get the demand up then maybe we'll get some other business owners and other people saying you know what? I'm going to open up a spot here, or I'm going to put a club back here. But right now I see too many clubs open up and fall by the wayside. Too many venues are suffering because they're not able to make the kind of money off promoting jazz music.

MR: Okay. This might be a tough question, but what kind of things make you angry, either musically or just in life?

WH: I would still say pretty much the same things is people not being human. And that covers a whole lot. I mean when you look at, like be it war, racism, senseless killings, all of it. Because it's hurtful and it angers you — because we look at all the technology that we have nowadays, the things that we can do — you know talk to somebody from around the world via the computer or send an instant message. You look at all this wonderful technology and we still can't get along? I mean that to me is always my bug. All the things that we've come up with and helped to create, but we can't treat each other fairly. So that will always anger me, be it whatever it is, race relations, just not wanting to treat other human beings with adequate due respect. I think this should anger everybody.

MR: Are you a spiritual — do you think of yourself as a spiritual person?

WH: Oh very much so. Very much so. And I do believe, I always tell a lot of my students for this music to be approached right and properly you really have to be. I think the majority of those guys who played the music that I knew were. Those guys that I named to you

that I was close with or I worked with were. A lot of times they may not have worn it on their sleeves, but if you got to know them, okay, how they conducted themselves, you knew that there was something underlying in there that was intact. You know, Billy Taylor, Max Roach, Billy Higgins, Jackie McLean, Abdullah Ibrahim. All those guys that I spent time with that had a big influence on me, you know Betty, you knew that there was some things intact. And it had to be for them to be the kind of people that they were. And that was the other beautiful thing about jazz for me too is the way the musicians were. And I think that's something that's missing in our society that we need is that all the musicians that I saw, they were so dignified. I mean they were gentlemen.

MR: The Joe Wilders of the world.

WH: Right. It's like polished. As far as you know, they might not have had two nickels. You know what I mean? But you know they were still dignified. It was something in their intent. It was something that they were trying to say. It was a message in all of it.

MR: Again, this is sometimes a hard question. What's the best gig or series of gigs you ever had, and on the other hand what might have been the worst?

WH: I don't know if I can ever say I've had a worst. I mean all the gigs I've had have been important and great to me. Because I'm still a fan of the music. You know what I mean? Every time I can still get on the bandstand with those guys that I have posted on my wall, you know, I have the album covers tacked up or I had read the interviews or you know what I mean? For me to have them still be around and call me up. Wow. You know what I mean? Like sometimes like when Max would call me up. Like wow. I actually remember sitting in that bedroom as a kid hearing my first Max Roach-Clifford Brown record. You know what I mean? So I mean when I can talk to him on the phone and he'll call my name it's like — it's being a part of something. Being accepted you know. Having the stamp of approval. At the same time I had so much respect for him. Even sometimes they would call me up for gigs I would still light up like somebody else was getting a big gift for, you know, Christmas day or something. It's like wow.

MR: Nice. That's a great sentiment. Playing with those guys that were on the wall.

WH: Yeah.

MR: That's great.

WH: I mean even tonight because still I always think about Dick Hyman. Dick Hyman's in that Charlie Parker video. You know what I mean? One of the few videos of Charlie Parker and he had the chance to sit there with Charlie Parker. Tonight I'll be sitting with him. I mean I'm a history buff so all those things are always — you're grateful.

MR: I totally agree. Like Bucky. He'll just say something in passing. "Oh that thing I did with Paul McCartney recently" or, like what? It was so much their day to day, they got on this level and it was always good.

WH: Yeah you can't beat it.

MR: Well is there anything you'd like to wrap up with that I haven't asked you about?

WH: Oh not that I can think of. I think we covered quite a bit, unless there's something that you want to go over.

MR: How do you promote your own group? Do you have help with that?

WH: I try to borrow help whenever I can get it. I take any help when I can get home to it. And I try to do the very best I can. I still get things printed up, try to do this social media thing, which a lot of times I have to ask either some youngsters or some people that are more in tune. Because still with some of the social media and computer stuff I probably might not ever, because when I hear people talking about tweeting and getting on Twitter, I can't see myself just everyday, "hey I'm here" and you know.

MR: Has the importance of making recordings changed?

WH: Yeah there's very few of them and nowadays for someone to record there's not a whole lot you can do with them. Because, and that's the other thing that happened. This hurt quite a bit. I think the industry wasn't prepared either for where things were going. So you know it's kind of like well we came on the scene in the 80s and we were one of the first bands to start going CDs. You know what I mean? That format.

MR: Yeah. That was the time, yeah.

WH: So I think when we came it was us and Wynton and Branford and Roy Hargrove came a little behind us, but we were some of the first, our first recording was album, CD and cassette. So now all that's changed. But I don't think the industry saw a lot of things coming. So now with the computer and the digital downloads and then one of the first things that hurt them, you know, Tower Records had come in, like in what was that in the late 70s, early 80s. And they killed all the Mom and Pop stores because they were such a big chain. You know it's almost like WalMart. Nobody could compete. So a lot of your Mom and Pop stores went out then. Then when Tower failed there's nothing really. So you know nobody was really prepared for all that. So I think even for record companies and stuff now, a lot of thought has to be given because there's not a whole lot of places to sell records unless the musicians are selling them off the bandstand themselves. So doing CDs is a little trickier.

MR: It feels like you should.

WH: Oh you have to, hoping to get some airplay, keep your name out there. But the thing is it's almost like you're doing it and everybody almost kind of knows well if we sell X amount we're lucky. You know what I mean?

MR: Right. It's not going to be a money maker.

WH: Right.

MR: But promotion. Yeah. Well I'm looking forward to hearing you tonight —

WH: Oh I'm looking forward to it.

MR: and sharing some music. And thanks for your time today.

WH: Oh I appreciate it much.

MR: Okay. Thanks a lot.